

Chapter 12-1

Lin Xingcan frowned upon hearing this, glaring at her friend, "If she's not Liang Shi, then who could she be?"

Her friend looked innocent, "Transmigration into a book? Transmigration into a TV drama? Or maybe soul transmigration? Body snatching? All are possible."

The atmosphere suddenly froze.

Everyone looked at the speaker with the gaze reserved for an idiot. This was Su Meiqi, the heiress of Haiwei Jewelry, who loved reading novels the most.

Especially during that period when the news said they would witness a once-in-a-century Ten Star Alignment¹, she found a novel with a female protagonist who shared her name, stayed up three nights straight to finish reading it and memorized the entire text, swearing confidently that she would definitely be able to create an era belonging to herself.

The result... the Ten Star Alignment had passed long ago, and Su Meiqi was still here.

Because of this, Su Meiqi had been mocked countless times at socialite gatherings.

"Are you obsessed?" Lin Xingcan rolled her eyes, "You actually believe such ridiculous things?"

"Why not believe it?" Su Meiqi shrugged, completely unfazed as she said, "Don't you think she's changed? Plus, Cheng Ran even posted on social media indirectly criticizing her, which probably has something to do with her change as well. So under these circumstances, what's more believable than transmigration?"

"Then tell me, what did she transmigrate into?" Lin Xingcan sneered, "A book? A TV drama?"

"Book transmigration is more likely." When Su Meiqi talked about this, her eyes practically glowed, wishing she could leave immediately to run to Liang Shi and grab her to ask about the secrets of book transmigration, "Based on all her behavior, she really seems like she transmigrated into a book, but..."

She paused.

For a moment, no one picked up her conversation.

After a few seconds, she said in a regretful tone, "Nowadays, book transmigration heroines are all very smart. They never go OOC². Her OOC is too severe, seriously deviating from Liang Shi's character setup. She doesn't seem very intelligent."

Everyone fell silent.

A few seconds later, Su Meiqi asked seriously, "Isn't that right?"

Lin Xingcan shook her head and walked forward, "Too ridiculous. I should go ask Aunt Liang what's going on."

One friend patted Su Meiqi's shoulder, "I know Zhao Xuning, want me to introduce you so you can make a film?"

Another friend sighed, "Meiqi, this is an illness that needs treatment."

Su Meiqi: "..."

She was being serious.

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Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu returned to the hotel.

Xu Qingzhu still maintained her aloof demeanor, standing at opposite ends of the elevator like north and south poles, not even exchanging glances.

Liang Shi wanted to explain the situation from earlier to Xu Qingzhu, but also felt there wasn't much to explain.

What she had just done... should have been a perfect girlfriend performance, right?

But Xu Qingzhu had no reaction.

It should be just like she said before - she didn't like her anymore.

So she didn't care whether there were other women around her, nor did she care what her reactions would be.

Even if she hadn't been there earlier, Xu Qingzhu could have handled it well.

She had an inexplicable trust in Xu Qingzhu.

The elevator reached the top floor. Xu Qingzhu glanced at her phone, frowned slightly, but leaned closer to her the moment the elevator doors slowly opened.

Liang Shi stepped aside to maintain distance.

"Act with me," Xu Qingzhu said, "It won't take long, and won't delay you too much."

Liang Shi's heart relaxed somewhat, "Okay."

Then she asked, "How do you need me to cooperate?"

She definitely didn't want to say the wrong thing again and make Xu Qingzhu angry, then have to endure the system's unreasonable punishment.

Really... very unlucky.

Xu Qingzhu thought for a moment, then shook her head, "No need, just stand there as background decoration."

"Alright." Liang Shi thought about it and still advised, "Talk properly with your sister. She's still young after all. Having her idol merchandise torn up would naturally make her angry - that's how all young girls are. First appease her, at worst I'll find someone to compensate her with new ones. Don't get into a fight with family over these things, it's really not worth it."

If Liang Shi had family, she would definitely get along well with them.

But she didn't have any.

So she really envied Xu Qingzhu's family.

A kind mother, a father who could provide shelter from storms, and a sister who might not be very well-behaved but was occasionally obedient and could be confided in.

"Why do your words sound like 'wanting to care for one's parents but they're no longer there'³?" Xu Qingzhu looked at her while entering the password, saying in a low voice, "This doesn't sound like something Liang Shi would say."

Liang Shi: "..."

She inexplicably felt like she was being tested again.

"No," Liang Shi wanted to explain, but Xu Qingzhu said, "I remember last month you had a big fight with Uncle Liang because you didn't get that villa in the north of the city."

Liang Shi: "..."

Really?

She couldn't tell for a moment whether Xu Qingzhu was testing her or just casually teasing.

Because she had no memories related to this incident in her mind.

Fortunately, Xu Qingzhu didn't dwell on this matter either.

When they entered, Xu Qingya was lying on the sofa wearing Bluetooth earphones. Her changed pants were still quite short, with her long, slender white legs exposed. Liang Shi turned away and didn't look further.

Xu Qingzhu walked over and patted her leg, indicating for her to get up.

Xu Qingya reluctantly took off her Bluetooth earphones, "What?"

"Hungry, right?" Xu Qingzhu's tone was no longer stern like before, but gentle, "Come on, let's go eat."

Xu Qingya looked puzzled, "Huh?"

"What are you standing there dazed for?" Xu Qingzhu said, "Change into long pants, we're going out to eat."

"What do you mean?" Xu Qingya frowned, "You're not planning to call Mom and Dad while we're eating, are you? Let me tell you, I can't swallow this anger. He threw away my idol merchandise - do you know how hard those albums are to find? They're all limited edition, and now even secondhand ones are impossible to get."

"No, Mom told you to stay outside and clear your head," Xu Qingzhu said, "You and Dad both need to cool down. I won't lecture you either, let's just go eat. Liang Shi and I still have things to do, we'll leave after eating."

Although Xu Qingya didn't quite believe it, she was indeed hungry. She stuffed her Bluetooth earphones into her bag and pointed at Xu Qingzhu, "Sis, you better not be lying to me."

"When have I ever lied to you?" Xu Qingzhu said.

Xu Qingya snorted softly and said nothing more.

Footnotes:

¹ **Ten Star Alignment (十星连珠)**: An extremely rare astronomical phenomenon where ten celestial bodies align in a straight line. In Chinese culture and web novels, such events are often considered auspicious times for supernatural occurrences like transmigration.

² **OOC**: "Out of Character" - when a character acts in a way that contradicts their established personality or behavior patterns. This is common internet slang used in fan fiction and online novel communities.

³ **"Wanting to care for one's parents but they're no longer there" (子欲養而親不在)**: A classical Chinese idiom expressing regret about not being able to care for one's parents because they have passed away. It emphasizes the importance of filial piety while one still has the chance.

Chapter 12-2

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Liang Shi wasn't familiar with the restaurants around here and didn't know which ones were good.

Fortunately, Xu Qingzhu didn't ask her to choose. As soon as they got in the car, she handed over her phone with the destination already set, telling her to just follow the GPS.

After arriving at the restaurant, Liang Shi went to park the car first, letting the Xu sisters go in ahead.

The parking lot was quiet. She sat in the driver's seat for a while, waiting until her spirits had recovered somewhat before going in.

This was a very elegant Western restaurant. Xu Qingzhu had already ordered for her in advance. After she went in, she politely said thank you.

Xu Qingya looked up at her, "Sister Liang Shi, you now..."

Liang Shi: "Hmm?"

Xu Qingya clicked her tongue, "Have a bit of a wife-slave¹ quality to you."

"Do I?" Liang Shi awkwardly touched her nose tip. She was just being polite by saying thank you.

How did this get connected to being a wife-slave?

"Yes, yes, you do." Xu Qingya nodded frantically, "Everyone who knows you, who doesn't know that the Liang family's second miss is someone who shows no respect to elders and is arrogant and unruly?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Ah, this.

"Alright." Just then their food arrived, and Xu Qingzhu interrupted at the right moment, "Okay, let's eat."

Xu Qingya shrugged indifferently, "Maybe it was just rumors. I think Sister Liang Shi has always been pretty good."

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her, "How much benefit did she actually give you?"

"None. Don't you think Sister Liang Shi is good?" Xu Qingya asked.

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She said coldly and clearly, "Eat."

"If you think she's not good, why would you still marry her?" Xu Qingya made a cutting sound, then looked at Liang Shi with fangirl eyes, "Sister Liang Shi is so gentle with you."

Liang Shi herself felt unworthy listening to this.

Probably no one in the Xu family knew what kind of situation Xu Qingzhu had been in before.

After all, the original body was good at pretending in front of the Xu family.

Back then, to get Father Xu to marry Xu Qingzhu to her, she had even knelt in the Xu family's living room for an entire day.

The most terrifying thing was when everyone thought she treated you very well.

Only you yourself knew what kind of living hell you were going through.

Liang Shi looked at Xu Qingzhu, and her heart suddenly ached.

For a moment, she empathized completely.

Just like how everyone thought that being without father or mother meant she didn't have to be controlled, standing in the spotlight, bright and dazzling.

But no one knew how lonely she was when she returned alone to her empty home, not daring to fall in love, with no one to confide in.

Xu Qingzhu noticed her gaze and looked back, the corners of her lips curving, "What are you looking at me for? Eat."

Liang Shi forked over the foie gras from her plate, "You eat first, eat more."

"Such public displays of affection," Xu Qingya teased.

At this moment, Liang Shi's phone rang. She glanced at the screen - it was Cheng Ran.

She frowned and hung up.

Xu Qingya asked, "Why didn't you answer?"

Liang Shi blocked that number, "It's someone I don't really like."

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Meanwhile, on the other side of the city, at Cris Bar.

A beautiful-looking Alpha sat at the bar, drinking glass after glass of alcohol, dialing her phone with her fingers.

But the mechanical electronic voice came through the receiver: "Sorry, the number you have dialed is turned off."

The wine glass in her hand instantly flew out, shattering into transparent fragments.

Cheng Ran pressed her temples and couldn't help but swear, "Fuck."

"Liang Shi has really fucking lost her mind." Cheng Ran gulped down another mouthful of alcohol, "Just because of one Xu Qingzhu, she wants to cut ties with me? Besides, I fucking didn't even touch Xu Qingzhu. Who was the one bullying Xu Qingzhu all this time? Fuck. Trash, how did she suddenly start being such a bootlicker²?"

She cursed for a while, then let out a breath, "No, I need to know what the hell happened to this piece of shit."

"Could it be that Xu Qingzhu threatened her?" Cheng Ran said as she dialed a number, and the other side quickly picked up.

Cheng Ran pressed her temples and ordered with drunken authority, "Help me investigate someone."

"Who?"

Cheng Ran said, "Liang Shi."

After saying this, she added, "Also, Xu Qingzhu, and the Xu family's current financial situation."

A few seconds later, she added, "Most importantly, what exactly happened to Liang Shi at the hospital yesterday and today. I want to know every detail."

She didn't believe Liang Shi could change overnight.

Footnotes:

¹ **Wife-slave (老婆奴)**: Chinese slang term describing a man (or in this case, person) who is completely devoted to and controlled by their wife/romantic partner, often in a somewhat exaggerated or doting way. It implies being extremely accommodating and subservient to one's partner.

² **Bootlicker (舔狗)**: Internet slang referring to someone who desperately tries to please someone else (usually in romantic contexts) by being overly accommodating or submissive, often without getting anything in return. Similar to "simp" in English internet culture.